



Power BI Viewer

USER GUIDE

Sign in once and see all your organization's Power BI reports, dashboards, and apps in one clean desktop window - plus a hands-free slideshow for wall displays.

Version 2.0.4 · Windows & Mac · In-app version: **Settings** → **About** (also shown on the sign-in screen footer)

1 Welcome & why this app

Power BI Viewer is one tidy desktop window - on Windows and Mac - for your organization's Power BI reports, dashboards, and apps. No browser tabs, no clutter.

The big idea: sign in once

The sign-in window and the Power BI content you open share the **same secure login**. That means when you open a Power BI *App*, it does **not** ask you to sign in all over again. You sign in one time, and everything just opens.

What you get

One window for everything

Reports, dashboards, and apps - all in a single app, no juggling browser tabs.

Instant search

Press **Ctrl** + **K** and find any report, dashboard, app, or workspace as you type.

Wall-display slideshow

A hands-free, full-screen presentation/kiosk mode for TVs and lobby screens.

Export & switch accounts

Save a report or dashboard to PDF, and switch between work accounts cleanly.

New to the app? Start here

Read Section 2 (Install & first run), then Section 3 (The window & navigation). If you run a wall display, jump to Section 10 (Slideshow & Kiosk).

2 Install & first run

Download

Your team shares a download link to the **GitHub Releases** page. Pick the file for your computer:

- **Windows:** Power BI Viewer-<version>-Windows-Setup.exe
- **Mac (Apple Silicon - M1/M2/M3):** the -Mac-arm64.zip file
- **Mac (Intel):** the -Mac-x64.zip file

Not sure which Mac you have?

Click the Apple menu → **About This Mac**. If it mentions "Apple M1/M2/M3", choose **arm64**. If it says "Intel", choose **x64**.

Install on Windows

- 1 Double-click the downloaded ...Windows-Setup.exe.
- 2 Windows may show a blue **"Windows protected your PC"** screen that says "Unknown publisher". This is expected - the app is not code-signed yet, but it is safe (it is your own company's app).
- 3 Click **"More info"**, then click **"Run anyway"**.
- 4 Follow the installer. It installs just for you (no admin rights needed) and finishes in a few seconds.
- 5 Launch **Power BI Viewer** from the Start menu or the desktop shortcut.

Why the warning?

The app is currently **unsigned** (no code-signing certificate yet), so Windows SmartScreen flags it the first time. The "More info → Run anyway" click-through is normal and safe for your organization's own app.

SCREENSHOT

Windows SmartScreen: "Windows protected your PC" with "More info" and "Run anyway"

This is an operating-system screen and must be captured on a real install. Drop the image here.

The SmartScreen prompt you will see on first install (Windows).

Install on Mac

- 1 Double-click the downloaded .zip to unzip it.
- 2 Drag **Power BI Viewer.app** into your **Applications** folder.
- 3 The first time you open it, Mac shows "**cannot be opened**". Click **Cancel**.
- 4 Open **System Settings** → **Privacy & Security**, scroll down, and click "**Open Anyway**".
- 5 Confirm. The app opens. After this, it opens normally every time.

Updates

There is no automatic update

To update, download the newer release and install it. On **Windows**, run the new .exe (it replaces the old version in place). On **Mac**, replace the .app in Applications. To roll back, simply install an older release.

Optional: you can verify a download with Get-FileHash (Windows PowerShell) and compare the SHA-256 to the value your team published.

Your first sign-in

- 1 Launch the app. You will see the sign-in screen: the logo, "Power BI Viewer", and the version number in the footer.
- 2 Click the orange "**Sign in with Microsoft**" button. It shows "**Signing in...**" with a spinner while it works.
- 3 A Microsoft window appears. Enter your **work email and password**, and approve any multi-factor (MFA) prompt.
- 4 You land on the **Home** screen. That is it.

The sign-in screen. Click the orange "Sign in with Microsoft" button. The version shows in the footer.

If sign-in fails

A red **"Sign in failed"** bar appears with the reason. Just click **"Sign in with Microsoft"** again to retry. (See Troubleshooting if it keeps failing.)

If something goes wrong, you see a red "Sign in failed" bar - click the button to try again.

"Sign in only once" - really

Your sign-in is cached safely on disk and restored when you relaunch, so you normally go **straight to Home**. You will only be asked to sign in again after you sign out, switch accounts, leave it for a long time, or if your password or access changes (you may see "Session expired. Please sign in again.").

3 The window & navigation

Three parts: the title bar across the top, a sidebar on the left, and the main area in the middle.

The title bar (top)

- **Left:** the logo and "Power BI Viewer". (You can drag this bar to move the window.)
- **Center:** a search button - "Search reports and dashboards..." - with a **Ctrl + K** hint chip. Click it (or press the keys) to open search.
- **Right:** your **account avatar** (your initials in a colored circle) and a colored **tenant badge** showing your organization's domain (for example contoso.com). The badge color is set automatically from your domain, and it hides on narrow windows.

The title bar: logo (left), search button (center), avatar and tenant badge (right).

Click the avatar to open the **account menu**: your name and email, **Switch account**, and **Sign out**.

Click your avatar to reach Switch account and Sign out.

The sidebar (left)

A button at the top expands or collapses the sidebar. When collapsed it shows only icons; hover over an icon to see its name. The items are:

- **Top:** Home, Workspaces, Apps
- **Bottom (separated):** Settings

The screen you are on shows a **3px orange bar** on its left edge.

Heads up: the sidebar starts collapsed every time

The sidebar is **collapsed on every launch** - the app does not remember if you expanded it last time. Just click the toggle at the top to expand it again whenever you want labels.

Expanded - labels visible.

Collapsed - icons only (the default at launch).

The main area

This shows whatever screen you have selected. For keyboard users, a "skip to content" link is available at the very top.

4 Home

Home greets you by time of day and first name - for example, "Good morning, Sam" - with the subtitle "Access your Power BI reports and dashboards". A **Refresh** button at the top-right reloads the lists.

A populated Home: greeting, Featured Workspaces, Browse Workspaces, plus Frequent and Recent.

Featured Workspaces

What these cards do

The Featured Workspaces row shows up to three cards as a quick orientation aid. **Every card - and the whole section - takes you to the Workspaces page.** They do not open one specific workspace directly. If nothing has loaded yet, a placeholder tells you to use Browse Workspaces.

Browse Workspaces

The orange "**Browse Workspaces**" button is **always visible** - it is your main way into all your content.

Frequent & Recent

Once you have used the app a little, two more areas appear:

- **Frequent** - a strip of the items you open most.
- **Recent** - a list of what you opened recently. Each Recent item has an **Open** action and a **Slideshow / Presentation** action.

First run looks emptier - that's normal

Before you have any history, Home shows a **Welcome** card with your signed-in email and a **Sign out** button. Open a few reports and the Frequent and Recent areas will fill in.

First-run Home: the Welcome card with your email and a Sign out button.

5 Browse: Workspaces & Apps

The Workspaces page

You see a list of **workspace rows** (each with a folder icon and name). Click a row to **expand** it and load its contents:

- **Reports** - blue document icon,  badge
- **Dashboards** - green board icon,  badge

A small **count badge** shows how many items the workspace holds. Click any report or dashboard to open it. A **Refresh** button re-fetches the list.

An expanded workspace showing Reports and Dashboards, type badges, and the item-count badge.

If part of a workspace won't load

If reports, dashboards, or both fail to load, a small warning row appears with a **Retry** button - the rest of the workspace still works.

The Apps page

A grid of **app cards**, each showing the app name, who published it, and the last-update date, with an **Open** button.

The Apps page: each card has Open, the publisher, and the last-update date.

Don't see an app you were given?

The Apps list only shows apps you have **installed**. To fix it, see "I don't see an app" in Troubleshooting and Appendix A (Admin setup). Empty state reads: "No apps found. Apps published to you will appear here."

6 Viewing a report

Open a report from Home, Workspaces, or Search. A toolbar runs across the top of the report.

The report toolbar

From left to right:

- **Back** - returns you to where you were (also shown as a breadcrumb, "Home > <report name>").
- **Data refreshed** - when the report's data was last updated, e.g. "Data refreshed: 6/7/2026 14:30 CT". If the data is more than 24 hours old, this turns a **warning color with a ⚠ marker**. It is hidden if the time is unknown.
- **Refresh** - reloads the report (shows "Refreshing..." and is disabled while busy).
- **Export PDF** - saves the current view to PDF (shows "Exporting..." while busy). See Section 11.
- **Slideshow** - starts presentation mode (reports only). See Section 10.
- **Full screen** - the corner-arrows icon.

The report toolbar with all its buttons, including the Slideshow button.

When data is over 24 hours old, "Data refreshed" turns to a warning color with a ⚠ marker.

Working with the report

The report keeps its native Power BI **filters pane** and **page navigation** - interact exactly as you would on the web.

Full screen & page navigation

- Click the **corner-arrows** icon to enter full screen. Press **Esc** or click again to exit.
- On a multi-page report, use the  and  arrow keys to change pages. A corner hint reads "← → Arrow keys to navigate pages (n/total)".

SCREENSHOT

Full-screen page-nav hint pill: "← → Arrow keys to navigate pages (n/total)"

Needs a live multi-page report in full screen. Drop the image here.

The corner hint that appears in full screen on multi-page reports.

If a report won't load

You will see: "This report could not be loaded. You may not have access, or it may have been removed." Click **Try again**. Items that have truly been removed are automatically cleared from your Recent and Frequent lists.

7 Viewing a dashboard

Dashboards have a similar toolbar to reports, with one key difference.

The dashboard toolbar

Back ("Home > <dashboard>"), Data refreshed, Refresh, Export PDF, and Full screen.

No Slideshow on dashboards

Slideshow is **report-only**. There is intentionally **no Slideshow button** on the dashboard toolbar.

The dashboard toolbar - note there is no Slideshow button (compare with the report toolbar above).

Drilling into tiles

Click any **tile** to drill through to the report behind it. Use **Back** to return to the dashboard.

What "Data refreshed" means on a dashboard

A dashboard pulls from many datasets, so its "Data refreshed" shows the **oldest (stalest)** refresh time across all tiles - your "is anything stale?" signal. If no tile exposes a dataset refresh history, the label is hidden entirely (so you are never shown a misleading value).

8 Viewing an app

Opening an app loads the full **app.powerbi.com** experience right inside the window.

- The toolbar has just two items: "**Back to Apps**" and **Refresh**.
- Navigate inside the app using its own menus, exactly as on the web.
- Thanks to the shared sign-in, the app **does not ask you to sign in again**.

A brief blip on first open is normal

The very first cold open may flash a sub-resource glitch that resolves on its own. Only a true main-page failure shows "Failed to load app: ..." with a **Try again** button - and that usually loads on the second attempt.

SCREENSHOT

App viewer: the "Back to Apps" + Refresh toolbar with the embedded
app.powerbi.com content

The embedded app needs a live signed-in session to render. Drop a real screenshot here.

The app viewer - just "Back to Apps" and Refresh, with the live app embedded below.

9 Search

Press **Ctrl** + **K** (**Cmd** + **K** on Mac) from anywhere, or click the title-bar search box.

The placeholder reads "Search reports, dashboards, apps, and workspaces...". Results appear **as you type** (after a brief pause), each with a type icon and label - **Report** **Dashboard** **App** **Workspace** - plus the workspace it lives in.

Search results with type labels and workspace names. The footer shows the keyboard hints.

Using the keyboard

- **↑** / **↓** - move between results (your mouse hover also selects)
- **Enter** - open the highlighted result
- **Esc** - close search
- The **×** (**Dismiss**) button clears the box

Choosing a Workspace result

Selecting a **Workspace** result jumps to the Workspaces page and **auto-expands** that workspace for you. If nothing matches you get "No results found for ...", and a non-blocking bar may note if part of the search failed.

10 Slideshow & wall-display (Kiosk)

Slideshow turns a report into a full-screen, auto-advancing presentation - perfect for a TV or lobby screen.

Start a slideshow

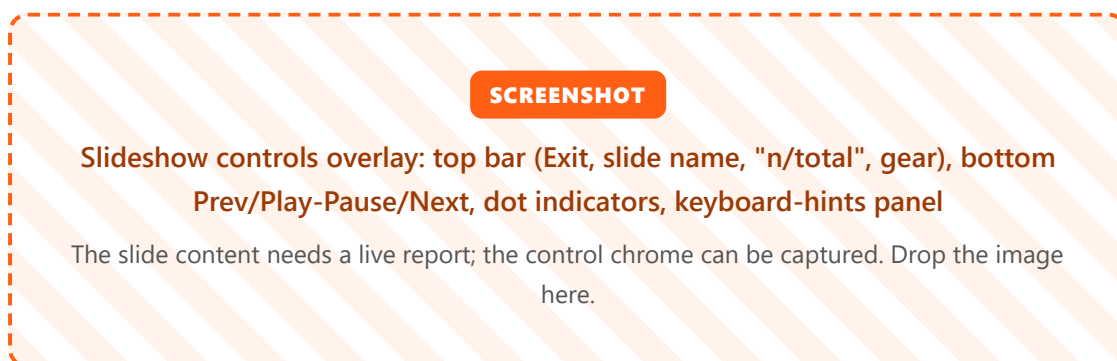
- 1 Open a **report** (slideshow is report-only).
- 2 Click **Slideshow** in the toolbar. It goes full screen and shows the first slide.
- 3 It only auto-advances when it is **playing** - use Play/Pause to control it.

Slides can be the report's **pages**, its **bookmarks**, or **both** - you choose this with "Slideshow mode" in Settings.

On-screen controls

The controls fade away after about 3 seconds of no mouse movement while playing; move the mouse to bring them back.

- **Top bar:** Exit (left), the current slide name/type, a counter "(n / total)", and a **gear** to drag the advance interval.
- **Bottom:** Previous / Play-Pause / Next.
- **Indicators:** a row of dots for 20 slides or fewer (bookmark dots are ringed), or a scrubber slider for more than 20 slides.
- A corner panel shows the keyboard hints.



The slideshow controls (chrome). The slide itself is the live Power BI report.

Kiosk mode (unattended wall display)

Turn on "**Auto-start slideshow**" in Settings. Now opening a report's slideshow **plays immediately and runs unattended**. In kiosk mode the app:

- Keeps the display **awake** (it blocks power-save/sleep).

- Hides the **mouse cursor after 4 seconds** of no movement (it reappears when you move the mouse).
- If a slide errors, it **auto-retries** with a backoff of 5s → 30s → 60s, then keeps trying every 60s.

How to exit a slideshow

Manual slideshow

(you clicked Slideshow)

Press **Esc** once.

Kiosk / auto-started

(started on its own)

A single **Esc** is **intentionally ignored**. To exit, **hold Esc for 3 seconds**, or press **Ctrl + Shift + Q**.

Always visible

A faint reminder sits in the **bottom-right corner** at all times:
"Press Esc to exit" (manual) or "Hold Esc 3s to exit / or Ctrl+Shift+Q" (kiosk).

The persistent bottom-right exit reminder. (Kiosk mode shows "Hold Esc 3s to exit / or Ctrl+Shift+Q".)

Why Ctrl+Shift+Q, not Ctrl+Shift+Esc?

Windows reserves **Ctrl + Shift + Esc** for Task Manager, so the app uses **Ctrl + Shift + Q** instead.

Slideshow keyboard shortcuts

- **→** or **Space** - next slide
- **←** - previous slide
- **P** - play / pause
- **Esc** - exit a manual slideshow (or close the gear panel if it is open)

11 Export to PDF

On a report or dashboard, click **Export PDF**.

- 1 Set up the view first - the export captures the **current view** (the active page, plus any filters and bookmarks you have applied on reports).
- 2 Click **Export PDF**. The button shows "Exporting...".
- 3 A short status appears in the toolbar - for example "Exported to PDF" (or an error if something went wrong).

Apps cannot be exported

Export to PDF is available on reports and dashboards only. App views do not have an Export button.

12 Accounts (switch / sign out)

Click your **avatar** (top-right) to open the account menu showing your name and email.

Switch account

A clean switch

Switch account fully signs out the current session - it clears caches and cookies so **no data carries over** between accounts - then reopens Microsoft with the account picker so you can choose a different one.

Sign out

Sign out opens a confirmation dialog titled "**Sign out?**" that reads: "You will be returned to the sign-in screen. Any open reports will be closed." Choose **Cancel** or **Sign out**. (There is also a Sign out button in Settings → Account.)

The "Sign out?" confirmation dialog.

13 Settings reference

Open Settings from the **bottom of the sidebar**. The cards appear in this order.

Settings - top (Account, Appearance, Slideshow).

Settings - bottom (Data Refresh, Usage History, Reset, About).

CARD	WHAT IT DOES
Account	Your name, email, and a Sign out button.
Appearance	Theme: Light / Dark / System (applies immediately). <i>Default is Dark.</i>
Slideshow / Presentation Mode	Auto-advance interval (5 seconds to 5 minutes, in 5-second steps); Slideshow mode (Pages only / Bookmarks only / Pages and bookmarks); Auto-start slideshow (On/Off - On enables kiosk exit rules).
Launch on Startup	Startup behavior: Show home screen, or Open a specific report. When set to a report, a picker lets you choose from your recent/frequent reports (dashboards are not eligible; an empty hint shows if you have none yet).
Data Refresh	Auto-refresh reports (On/Off; <i>default On</i>); Refresh interval (1 minute to 2 hours), shown when auto-refresh is on.
Usage History	Clear usage history on sign-out: Never / Always / On shared machine. Plus a " Clear usage history now " button (empties Recent and Frequent).
Reset	"Reset all settings to defaults" - this does <i>not</i> sign you out.
About	"Power BI Viewer v2.0.4" plus " Check for updates ", which opens the GitHub Releases page in your browser (there is no in-app auto-update).

Good to know about defaults

The app ships with **Dark** theme and **Auto-refresh On** by default - so don't be surprised if it looks dark and your reports refresh on their own.

Light vs. Dark

Home in Light theme.

Home in Dark theme (the default).

14 Keyboard shortcuts

WHERE	KEYS	WHAT IT DOES
Anywhere	Ctrl + K (Cmd + K Mac)	Open Search
Search	↑ / ↓	Move between results
Search	Enter	Open the highlighted result
Search	Esc	Close search
Report (full screen)	← / →	Previous / next report page
Report (full screen)	Esc	Leave full screen
Slideshow	→ or Space	Next slide
Slideshow	←	Previous slide
Slideshow	P	Play / pause
Slideshow (manual)	Esc	Exit (or close the gear panel if open)
Slideshow scrubber (decks > 20 slides, when focused)	← / → or ↑ / ↓ , Home , End	Step slides; jump to first / last
Kiosk / auto-started slideshow	Hold Esc 3s , or Ctrl + Shift + Q	Exit (a single Esc is ignored)

Two things to remember

The kiosk exit chord is **Ctrl** + **Shift** + **Q** - not **Ctrl** + **Shift** + **Esc** (that's Windows Task Manager). There is no in-app minimize/maximize shortcut - use the normal window controls in the title bar.

15 Troubleshooting & FAQ

Click any question to expand the answer.

Windows says "Windows protected your PC / Unknown publisher"

This is expected because the app is currently unsigned. Click **"More info"**, then **"Run anyway"**, and continue the installer. It is safe - it is your own organization's app. (On Mac, the equivalent is **System Settings → Privacy & Security → "Open Anyway"**.)

I don't see an app I was granted access to

Power BI's Apps list only shows apps you have **installed**. Fix it one of two ways:

(a) Admin push (no user action): when publishing or updating the app, set a security-group audience, enable the tenant setting **"Push apps to end users"**, and tick **"Install this app automatically"**. The app then appears in users' lists on its own. (See Appendix A.)

(b) Install it yourself: open the app once on the Power BI website (app.powerbi.com) to install it for your account, then return to Power BI Viewer and click **Refresh** on the Apps page.

It's asking me to sign in again

You normally stay signed in. A re-prompt is normal after you **Sign out**, **Switch account**, leave it for a long gap, or after a password/access change ("Session expired. Please sign in again."). Just click **"Sign in with Microsoft"** again.

I got a red "Sign in failed" bar

Usually a network hiccup, a cancelled window, or a verification step. Click **"Sign in with Microsoft"** to retry. If the message mentions consent or access, contact your admin - the app may need consent for Power BI access in your tenant.

I'm seeing another account's items

Click your **avatar** (top-right) → **Switch account** and pick the right one; the app fully clears the old session first, so nothing carries over. To leave entirely, choose **Sign out** and confirm.

I'm stuck in a slideshow / can't get out

If **you** started it, press **Esc** once. If it started **on its own** (kiosk), **hold Esc for 3 seconds** or press **Ctrl + Shift + Q**. A reminder is always in the bottom-right corner.

A report or dashboard won't load

Click **"Try again"**. If it still fails, you may not have access, or it was moved/removed. Use **Back** and try another item. **Ctrl + K** search helps confirm the exact name. Removed items disappear from Recent/Frequent automatically.

"Failed to load app" on the first open

Cold opens occasionally blip on a sub-resource. Click **Try again / Refresh** - it usually loads on the second attempt.

The wall-display screen went dark

The app keeps the display awake while a slideshow is **playing**. If it still sleeps, confirm the slideshow is actually playing (not paused), then have the setup person check the monitor's and computer's own power settings.

How do I change how fast slides advance?

During a slideshow, move the mouse, click the **gear**, and drag the Interval. Or beforehand in **Settings** → **Slideshow / Presentation Mode** → **Auto-advance interval** (5 seconds to 5 minutes).

The Apps / report list looks stale

Click **Refresh** on the page - Home, Workspaces, and Apps each have one - to re-fetch the latest from Power BI.

How do I check for a newer version?

Settings → **About** → "**Check for updates**" opens the GitHub Releases page in your browser. There is no automatic update - download and run the newer installer. Knowing your version (Settings → About) also helps support.

A Appendix: Admin setup (Power BI tenant)

For administrators. This solves the most common end-user issue: "I don't see my app."

Why a user might not see an app

Power BI Viewer lists apps through the Power BI REST API, which only returns apps the user has **installed**. A user who was merely granted access (via a security group) will **not** see the app until it is installed for them.

Preferred fix: push the app (zero user action)

- 1 In the **Power BI / Fabric Admin portal**, enable the tenant setting "**Push apps to end users**".
- 2 When publishing or **updating** the app, set the app's **audience to a security group**.
- 3 Tick "**Install this app automatically**" - this pushes the app into each member's Apps list.
- 4 **Re-publish / update** the app after changing audiences so the push takes effect.

User self-serve fallback

The user opens the app once at **app.powerbi.com** (the website) to install it for their account, then returns to Power BI Viewer and clicks **Refresh** on the Apps page.

Operator notes

- The app is **unsigned**, so the Windows SmartScreen click-through is expected until a code-signing certificate (OV/EV) is added.
- Distribution and updates are **manual via GitHub Releases** (repo: BCABC4353/PBIVIEWER). There is **no auto-update**.
- "Check for updates" simply opens the latest Releases page in the browser.